LINE, LEGACY, LEGITIMACY:

JEHANGIR IN THE PADSHAHNAMA

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The reign of the Mughal dynasty in India was one of the most culturally rich and significant time periods in the history of the country. Spanning almost three centuries, the rule of the Mughals is especially salient in creating an oeuvre of art that stemmed from a cross-cultural exchange between the aesthetics of the Persian and Iranian art heritage with the contemporary traditions of Indian practitioners. This cultural exchange was a deliberate process – the Mughal Empire distinguishes itself in the history of India's invaders as a time of pluralism and acceptance, most evident in the philosophy of the third Emperor Akbar's 'Din-e-Ilahi' or Religion of God, which included elements from Islam, Hinduism, Christianity and even Zoroastrianism (Klaus 2005). However, the existence of these tolerant philosophies did not imply a corresponding proliferation of them – and it is to this end that the Mughal Emperors deployed the use of art to consolidate and present their politics to their subjects.

In the following essay, I will undertake a brief overview of the propagandic function of art in the Mughal era, and how it clashes with principles of legacy, genealogy and filial piety. In particular, I focus on the presentation of the fourth Emperor Jehangir as he is depicted in the official memoirs of his son and successor, Shah Jahan. I argue that the prowess of the Mughal dynasty contends with and is even undermined by its own tumultuous history; further, I posit that this contention is reified in the portrayal of Jehangir in the manuscript paintings commissioned by Shah Jahan.

Legacy in Propagandic Art

Rulers rely on the subjugation of the people to retain their seat of power. None were more aware of this than the Mughal Emperors, who were in the "precarious position of being a Muslim elite minority ruling over a vast territory of peoples largely of different creeds and cultures" (Koch 2017, 93).The Mughals were ostensibly foreign – the first Mughal Emperor of India (then referred to as Hindustan), Babur, was a descendant of Timur and Genghis Khan, hailing from Central Asia. As outlined in Klaus (2005), Babur went on to defeat the

Delhi Sultanate's Ibrahim Lodi to establish the Mughal Empire in India. Babur, and his successor and son, Humayun did not enjoy comfortable reigns in India, with Humayun even being briefly driven back to Persia by insurgency. Indeed, it was this exile that facilitated the import of Persian culture to India, with Humayun bringing the artists, Mir Sayyid Ali and Abd us Samad, from the Shah's court in Persia back to his seat of power in Hindustan.

The fact that it was during this instable time that the seed of Mughal art was sowed makes it seem but natural that art was deployed as a just another device to consolidate power. In particular, Humayun commissioned a painting called "Princes of the House of Timur" (see Figure 1) as a reference to his genealogy as a descendant of the great Central Asian conqueror Timur. The figures in the painting are named within the art itself, another indication that Humayun wanted to be identified and connected to the name of Timur. Babur, his direct father, does not appear in this painting – in fact, he is almost eschewed in favour of Timur's reputation.

The composition of the painting also lends itself to these sort of symbols of power. The eye is drawn to the centre of the painting to the pavilion where the princes are seated, following the lines of the painting. These lines also serve to visually emphasize the distinction between the princes and the rest of the figures: the servants, including the workers and the cooks, are relegated to the back of the painting, whereas what seem to be nobles or aristocrats are arranged around the princes in the foreground. The predominant use of gold, along with the rich patterns of the decorated architecture vibrantly painted in the traditional Safavid style from Iran, provide images of opulence and grandeur, all serving to compound the image of the power of the princes.

Interestingly, the figures of Humayun's successors, his son Akbar and grandson Jehangir also feature in this artwork, rendered in accurate portrayal of their adult selves – despite the fact that Akbar was only a child at the time of this painting and Jehangir was not

even born. Their image was actually overwritten into the painting decades later by their artists. This signifies the continuation of the need to legitimise their lineage and assert their right to rule over the Empire by linking their identities to that of their fathers and their fathers' fathers, all the way to Timur. The painting speaks for itself as a symbol of the Mughal desire to embody and re-embody the power and authority of their lineage, but the very fact that this painting was preserved and altered across ages speaks to the generational success of the Mughal Emperor's project in the region.

The reign following Humayun, his son Akbar's, is widely regarded as the most prosperous reign of the Mughal dynasty – indeed, Akbar was by far the most popular and loved Mughal ruler. This was in no small part due to his liberal policies and his love for knowledge: Akbar's court was populated by scholars of various fields, from law, theology, philosophy to music, literature and art, who were treated as well as nobles in the court. There was a subsequent flourishing of the arts that led to Akbar been seen in great favour. In particular, Akbar's commission for a collection of illustrations and texts to formulate his biography led to the establishment of the Mughal tradition of commissioning the 'Namas' that contained the history of the king's rule.

Not only did Akbar commission his own Akbarnama, but also the Baburnama in honour of his grandfather and the establisher of the Mughal dynasty. This tradition continued into the reigns of Jehangir and Shah Jahan, who each commissioned their artists to create the Jehangirnama and Shahjahanama respectively. These works served as biographies for the kings – but more importantly, they show us how the kings wanted themselves to be remembered at the time. Both in the continuation of tradition as well as in the texts themselves, there is an emphasis of genealogy and right of rule which prevailed in the art that contributed to a national narrative at the time. There is a constant harkening to and evocation

of the lines of legacy that the kings come from – a notion that is disrupted by the actual events that took place between the succession of kings, as I will argue in the next section.



Figure 1. Princes of the House of Timur. c. 1550-55 at Kabul, Mir Sayyid Ali. Painted in gouache on cloth (cotton). Collection: The British Museum. Picture: British Museum Online Images.

Undermining the Lines of Legitimacy

So far, I have established that the Mughal dynasty legitimized its rule, consolidated its power and formulated its legacy through the establishment of paintings as sites of reputation-creation and the perpetuation of such traditions. To abandon or ignore this line of tradition, of

genealogy, would be to undermine the legitimacy of one's own rule and, by association, call into question the power of the throne. Even Akbar, who is by all accounts the most liberal and forward-thinking of the Mughals, did not (or perhaps could not) resist the urge to write his genealogy into his history.

However, this line of legacy and legitimacy to their fathers is constantly underwritten by the tumultuous fact of the historical events taking place. Jehangir's succession to the throne was made possible because of his arrest of his own father, leaving the throne for him to inherit. In turn, Jehangir's son, Shah Jahan, took the throne from him by staging a military coup against his father and then executing his brothers and cousins who may make a claim on the throne. Later, Shah Jahan's son Aurangzeb would frame and execute his brothers and imprison his father in his bid for the throne.

The Mughal manuscript paintings in some sense then serve as sites of this dissonance – on the one hand, it is not possible for the sons to publicly denounce their fathers as doing so is as good as revoking their birthright to the throne; on the other hand, it is impossible to deny the sheer violence committed by the sons against the fathers. It is in the art of Shah Jahan's biography, the Padshahnama, that these conflicts are displaced onto art. The literal content of the paintings fit in line with the narrative of the Mughal genealogy of power, but the peripheral symbols are allegorical of instability – the true meaning of the artwork sneaks in through the interpretative analysis of the painting.

Figures 2 and 3 depict scenes from Shah Jahan's biography, the Padshahnama, which narrativize the early part of Shah Jahan's life, where his father Jehangir ruled Hindustan as Emperor and Shah Jahan was a prince who went on military campaigns in the name of his father. In both paintings, Jehangir welcomes Shah Jahan into his court. There is a closeness – both of physical distance and of symbolic appearance – between the two men, Jehangir seems to hold Shah Jahan in a tender embrace when he returns from a war in the south, and gifts

him a turban in the other. Shah Jahan himself is in a position of submission to his father, accepting his regard as members of the court look on.

It is important to remember that this painting was commissioned after the death of Jehangir, during the rule of Shah Jahan. By this time, the popularity of Jehangir had waned – he was seen as a corrupt king who allowed his consort queen to rule in favour of consuming opium. Shah Jahan would not have wanted to be associated with him; however, there was no way he could revoke this association without revolting his own claim to throne.

Koch (2017) argues that the allegory of the paintings are reified in the smallest symbols. Namely, the space between the throne and the members of the court, placed in the centre of the painting, refer to the instable and corrupt reign of Jehangir. The symbols of power, seen from the commissions of Humayun and Akbar, here take on a note of excessiveness rather than power – they show the corrupt nature of Jehangir rather than his richness.



Figure 2. Jahangir Receives Prince Khurram on his return from the Deccan. c. 10 October 1617.



Figure 3. Jahangir presents Prince Khurram with a turban ornament.

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